and rent-seeking have certainly shifted conflict dynamics and most agree that some leaders are fighting for resources, but that is not what drives recruitment and tribute to the KIO/A, which has quite strong (although not uncritical) popular support. While Kachin civil society leaders express concerns that many high-ranking Kachin officers have become very rich from their positions due to resource extraction, they blame government tactics during the ceasefire. Recruitment, community mobilization, and payment of taxes or tribute still appear to be primarily driven by the desire not to be governed by the Burmese state, or subject to its chauvinistic control and cultural assimilation.

UNDERSTANDING THE RETURN TO ARMED CONFLICT IN 2011

Detailed analysis of the return to conflict by the KIO/A in June 2011, as the political transition to a new semi-civilian government commenced, will need to be the subject of another paper, but brief consideration is due here. The Kachin civil society leaders interviewed observed that the KIO/A lost a great deal of political capital during the seventeen-year ceasefire (1994–2011), as promises were not delivered (see also ICG 2013). The KIO/A took the initiative to open negotiations with the government in 1994 (ICG 2013), aiming for a nationwide ceasefire on behalf of all armed groups to be followed by political dialogue, but this initiative was not well received by other groups or the military. The KIO/A proposal to transform their education, health, police, and other civil departments into a state government was also rejected by the government, and KIO education, health, police, and other civil officers asking for transfer to state institutions were consistently rejected. Thus the ceasefire did not lead to a comprehensive agreement that would address the political self-determination rights and ideological clashes vis-à-vis the distribution of political power at the heart of 'processes of identification' examined in this chapter. Civil society activists argue that the central problem was the government's elite-led approach to transform the armed organization, by giving the elite commanders economic opportunities in a deliberate and explicit strategy of 'ceasefire capitalism' (see also Woods 2011). In place of the promised negotiation about political rights, power distribution, and equitable development, therefore, the concessions created evolving